

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Who's to blame for property tax bills?

Finger-pointing, opportunism abound after homeowners see large increases

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

It took little time after this year's Cook County property tax bills became public for the political gamesmanship to begin.

This year's bills showed Chicago homeowners' median property tax bills jumped 16.7% over last year, according to the Cook County treasurer, while the collective bills for commercial real estate in the Loop dropped by \$129 million.

Within days, the metastasizing debate over who was responsible for the rising tax burden collided with deepening ideological rifts in Chicago and Cook County. And it happened at an especially combustible moment — in the middle of the city's delayed budget season and as several key Democratic primary contests ramp up.

Mayor Brandon Johnson and his allies, eager to steer public anger away from City Hall, pointed to the so-called head tax — a levy on large employers that Johnson is trying to revive — as an alternative to raising property taxes to close next year's deficit.

Several aldermen, meanwhile, trained their fire on Cook County Assessor Fritz Kaegi, whose office set the new assessments last year. Kaegi, a frequent target who is up for reelection in 2026, responded by accusing the county's Board of Review, a three-member appeals body with which he has long feuded, of slashing downtown values.

And then there was the Chicago Teachers Union, one of Johnson's most powerful supporters, which cast the bills as evidence of inequity. "Billionaires are paying less

Turn to Blame, Page 2



The Chicago skyline can be seen behind freight train segments in the Norfolk Southern Ashland Yard on Tuesday. E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE

Rail merger could have lasting impact on city

Union Pacific says its proposal to acquire Norfolk Southern could unclog Chicago's bottleneck. Critics worry about rising costs and traffic tie-ups

By John Lippert
Chicago Tribune

By merging with Norfolk Southern, Union Pacific wants to create a coast-to-coast railroad to carry nearly half of all U.S. rail freight. Union Pacific says the \$85 billion merger would serve the public interest and win federal approval by unclogging Chicago,

the cradle of American railroad-ing and still its biggest and most notorious bottleneck.

But the "increased monopolistic power" of the combined railroad will drive up shipping costs and could kneecap America's global competitiveness, according to nine Republican attorneys general in a letter last month.

Shipping costs are already a

pocketbook issue for everyday Chicagoans. Americans received 66 packages on average in 2024, a 78% increase over seven years, according to Capital One retail data. During this time, the average price per package dropped by just 4%. Over time, Union Pacific's promise of greater post-merger efficiency could mean less congestion and pollution on Chicago's highways and on the northeast Illinois rail network that 1 in 4 U.S. freight trains now cross to get where they're going.

But neighborhoods located around tracks and terminals where the combined railroad may want to expand could get inun-

dated with more traffic tie-ups, noise and environmental damage, according to Earl Wacker, a former CSX executive and now a transportation consultant with RINA North America in Chicago.

"The influx of freight trains through Chicago has the potential to cause substantial delays in local commuters' schedules and inconvenience their daily lives," Wacker wrote in Railway Age magazine.

As soon as this week, Union Pacific plans to file a merger application with the federal Surface Transportation Board that will run into the thousands of pages,

Turn to Merger, Page 6



Sisters Kimberly and Rebecca George co-own Volumes Bookcafe in Chicago's Wicker Park neighborhood. The pair, who have owned the store for 10 years, plan to close it in January. DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bookstore's fate a familiar tale

A year after Barnes & Noble's opening in Wicker Park, indie Volumes Bookcafe is forced to close

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

Rebecca George likes to think that she is part of her customers' stories.

There have been two weddings and almost 20 engagements at Volumes Bookcafe, the bookstore she owns in Wicker Park. Debut authors launched successful

careers. Just a couple of months ago, she said, a baby took his first steps in between the bookshelves and now he's "cruising around like he owns the place."

It's these memories George said she'll miss the most when Volumes closes in January. It was a decision she and her sister, a co-owner, were forced to make due to a consistent 20% to 30%

drop in sales, a death knell for independent bookstores, which typically operate with tight profit margins.

"Bringing books to the world is important," George said. "All the children that you can get excited to read. The reluctant reader who comes in and you give them the perfect book. You become a part of people's lives."

George largely attributes the dip to a Barnes & Noble opening

Turn to Volumes, Page 4

No peace agreement yet in US-Ukraine talks

Rubio stresses future prosperity, as more airstrikes reported

By Josh Boak
and Aamer Madhani
Associated Press

HALLANDALE BEACH, Fla. — U.S. and Ukrainian officials completed around four hours of talks Sunday aimed at finding an endgame to the war between Russia and Ukraine.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio told reporters afterward that the session was productive, but work remains in the search for a peace deal.

"It's not just about the terms that ends fighting," he said. "It's about also the terms that set up Ukraine for long-term prosperity. ... I think we built on that

today, but there's more work to be done."

The high-level negotiations in Florida came days before President Donald Trump's special envoy, Steve Witkoff, is due in Moscow to meet with Russian leader Vladimir Putin.

Rubio, Witkoff and Jared Kushner, Trump's son-in-law, represented the American side in the talks, held at a sensitive time as Ukraine continues to push back against Russian forces that invaded in 2022 while dealing with a domestic corruption scandal.

Diplomats have focused on revisions to a U.S.-authored plan that was developed in negotiations between Washington and Moscow. That proposal has been criticized as being too weighted

Turn to Ukraine, Page 4

INSIDE

Chicago snowfall breaks November record, NWS says

Snowfall recorded Saturday at O'Hare International Airport was confirmed at 8.4 inches, the highest snowfall on a single calendar day in November since 1951. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

End-of-season college football takeaways

Illinois won 20-13 over Northwestern on a snowy Saturday night in Champaign. And Notre Dame made its case for a playoff berth with a 49-20 win against Stanford. **Chicago Sports**

